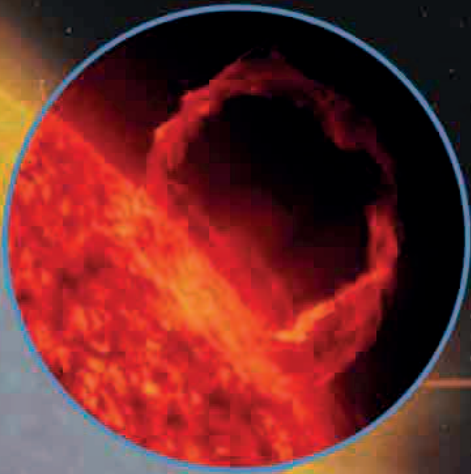


The Solar System

When the Sun formed from a cloud of dust and gas, some of the material spread out into a spinning disk. From this came eight orbiting planets and vast numbers of asteroids, comets, and smaller bits of space rock that sometimes crash to Earth as meteorites.

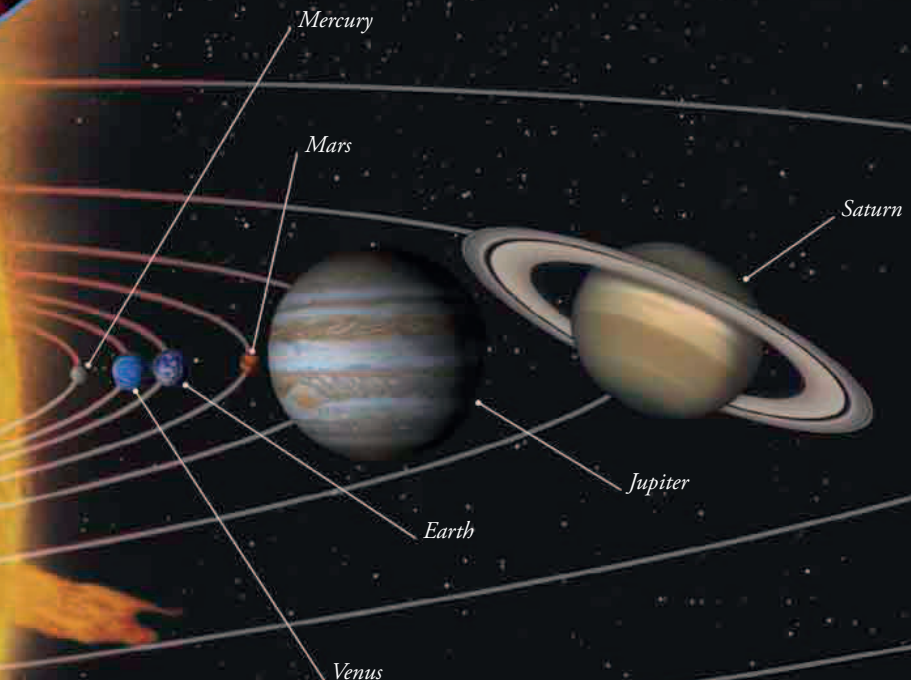


THE SUN

A star like many others in the sky, the Sun is a giant ball of hot gas that formed about 4.6 billion years ago. Nuclear reactions in its core release nuclear energy that heats its surface to around 10,800°F (6,000°C)—six times as hot as volcanic lava.

◀ HOT GAS

Colossal plumes of hot gas erupt from the Sun's surface and spill out into its atmosphere. Each one is far bigger than planet Earth.



ORBITING WORLDS

All the major planets orbit the Sun in almost the same plane, but at different distances. The planetary system is 7.5 billion miles (12 billion km) across, but since many comets and asteroids have much bigger orbits, the entire Solar System is at least 9.3 trillion miles (15 trillion km) wide.